Praise to the Incomparable One

Nirupamastava · Toh 1119 · Derge Tengyur
དཔེམེད་པར་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise to the Incomparable One, known in Sanskrit as the Niraupamyastava and in Tibetan as Pemé Par Töpa, is a short hymn in verse attributed to the master Nāgārjuna and traditionally counted among his collected praises of the Buddha. Opening with homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī, it lauds the Buddha as one who knows the absence of entities, who found peace not by abandoning saṃsāra but by not apprehending it at all, and who, though free of every concept and having a body whose nature is the Dharma itself, displays birth, awakening, the teaching of three vehicles, and passing into nirvāṇa for the sake of beings. It closes by dedicating the merit of the praise so that all beings may become vessels for the Buddha's profound teaching, and its colophon names the Indian scholar Kṛṣṇa Paṇḍita and the Tibetan translator Tsultrim Gyalwa as its translators. It is Toh 1119 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of hymns of praise, or stotra, and it expresses the Middle Way view of emptiness in devotional form.

In the language of India: nirupamastavaṃ
In the language of Tibet: Praise to the Incomparable One

Homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī.

You who strive to benefit this world,
Impoverished as it is by views,
Knowing the meaning of the absence of entities:
Incomparable One, to you I bow in praise.

That with the eye of a buddha
You have not seen even the slightest thing
Is your unsurpassed seeing;
It is the knowing of the meaning of reality.

In ultimate existence you have
Neither realizer nor anything to be realized;
How wonderful! The buddhas realize
The nature of reality, supremely hard to realize.

You did not bring anything at all into being,
Nor did you put a stop to phenomena;
Through the view of sameness

You attained the unsurpassed state.

You do not hold that nirvāṇa comes
Through having abandoned saṃsāra;
Rather, Protector, you realized the peace
That is the very non-apprehension of saṃsāra.

Because you know that thorough affliction
And purification have become of one taste,
The dharmadhātu, manifestly undivided,
Has become completely pure in every respect.

Lord, though nowhere at all
Did you utter even a single syllable,
You satisfied all beings to be trained, without exception,
With the rain of the Dharma.

Since you, whose mind is equal to space,
Have no attachment to the aggregates,
The elements, or the sense sources,
You do not depend on any phenomena at all.

Protector, though you never engage
Through the perception of sentient beings,
Toward sentient beings who suffer
You have become the very embodiment of compassion.

Pleasure and suffering, and likewise
Permanence, impermanence, and the rest:
Lord, through such varied conceptions
Your mind has never become attached.

Phenomena neither go nor come anywhere;
Just so, you are the one thus gone (tathāgata).
Nowhere is anything amassed;
Therefore you are also the knower of the ultimate.

Though you conform to all,
You do not arise anywhere at all;
Your births, your Dharma, and your bodies,
Great Sage, are inconceivable.

Beings, like echoes,
Free of being one or other,
Free of transmigrating and perishing:
This you realized, O Irreproachable One.

Free of permanence and annihilation,
Wholly free of characteristic and characterized,
Saṃsāra, like a dream or an illusory display,
Is what the Lord has decisively realized.

Down to the very ground of habitual tendencies
You abandoned afflictions and misdeeds;
And the intrinsic nature of the afflictions themselves
You made into nectar itself.

Hero, you saw forms as signless,
As though they were formless;
Yet your very body, ablaze with the major marks,
Is seen as a domain of form.

Seeing you as form is not seeing you,
Yet one says, "I have seen."
By seeing the Dharma one truly sees,
Yet the nature of reality is not seen.

Your body has no hollow within;
Though it has no flesh, bone, or blood,
Like the bow of the lord of the sky (the rainbow),
You display your body.

Your body has no illness and no impurity;
Though hunger and thirst do not arise in you,
In order to conform to the world
You display worldly conduct as well.

Though you, free of misdeeds, have abandoned
All the faults of karmic obscuration,
In order to care for sentient beings
You also teach the abandoning of karma.

Because the dharmadhātu has no divisions,
Lord, there are no divisions of vehicle;
Yet your teaching of three vehicles

Is in order to bring sentient beings in.

Your body, whose intrinsic nature is Dharma,
Is permanent, stable, and at peace;
Yet you, the Victor, for the sake of beings to be trained,
Displayed yourself as passing into nirvāṇa.

In countless world realms,
Your passing, your birth, and your full awakening
Are also seen by those devoted to you
Who aspire to liberation from saṃsāra.

Protector, though you have no volition
And no stirring of conceptual thought,
Spontaneously, of yourself, in the world
The deeds of a buddha come to pass.

Thus the Sugata's qualities, immeasurable and inconceivable,
Have been adorned with flowers; whatever merit has come from this,
Through it may all these sentient beings without exception
Become vessels for the Sage's Dharma, so supremely hard to realize.

This completes the Praise to the Incomparable One, composed by the noble master Nāgārjuna. It was translated by the Indian preceptor Kṛṣṇa Paṇḍita and the translator, the monk Tsultrim Gyalwa.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.